

Saudi Arabia



An oil-rich kingdom with laws based on the ultra-conservative principles of Wahhabi Islam.

400s CE Arabia is invaded by Ethiopians and Sassanians from Persia.

c.610 CE Muhammad begins preaching in Mecca. He moves against the ruling Quraysh and takes the city in 630. Mecca becomes the center of Islam, but the Arabian peninsula is otherwise sidelined under the Umayyad and Abbasid Caliphates and the Ottoman Sultanate.

1871 The Ottomans take control of the province of Hasa.

1891 Saud family are exiled to Kuwait.

1902 Abd al-Aziz (Ibn Saud) returns from exile and captures Riyadh.

1913–26 Ibn Saud and the Ikhwan sweep across Arabia, taking Hasa in 1913, Mecca in 1924, and Medina in 1925. In 1921 he takes the title Sultan of Najd, and in 1926 he is named King of the Hijaz.

1928–30 The Ikhwan rebel and are defeated after two years of civil war.

1932 Ibn Saud unifies his domain as Saudi Arabia.

1937 Oil reserves are discovered near Riyadh. Production begins within a year.

1953 King Saud succeeds to the throne.

1964 King Saud abdicates in favor of his brother Faisal.

1967 Saudi Arabia joins Jordan and Iraq against Israel in Six-Day War.

1973 Saudi Arabia imposes oil embargo on Western supporters of Israel.

1975 King Faisal assassinated by a nephew; succeeded by his brother Khalid.

1979 Muslim fundamentalists led by Juhaiman ibn Seif al-Otaibi seize Grand Mosque in Mecca.

1982 King Fahd succeeds on the death of his brother King Khalid.

1990–91 US, UK, French, Egyptian, and Syrian forces assemble in Saudi Arabia for the Gulf War against Iraq. Public executions are halted.

1993 King Fahd appoints 60-man Consultative Council (Majlis ash-Shoura).

1996 King Fahd briefly hands control to Crown Prince Abdullah after a stroke.

2001 Relations with US are strained after 15 Saudis take part in the 9/11 attack.

2005 King Fahd dies and is succeeded by Crown Prince Abdullah.

2005 First-ever national municipal elections are held (but the franchise is restricted to men).

2006 360 pilgrims are killed in a crush during the Hajj.

2009 The trials of 330 suspected Islamist terrorists conclude.

«174–77 The Ascent of Islam
«246–47 The Ottoman Empire
«440–41 The Oil Crisis

Yemen



In the poorest country in the Middle East, unified in 1990, tensions between north and south persist.

630 CE Muslim forces occupy Yemen.

1839 UK occupies Aden.

1849 Ottomans take control of north.

1918 North Yemen gains independence. Ruled by Imam Yahya.

1937 Aden made a crown colony.

1962 Imam deposed in a coup, Yemen Arab Republic (YAR) in north.

1962–70 Northern civil war between royalists and republicans.

1963 British-ruled Aden and Protectorate of Southern Arabia unified.

1967 British troops leave Aden.

1970 South Yemen renamed People's Democratic Republic of Yemen (PDRY) after radical Marxists seize power.

1972 War between YAR and PDRY ends in a peace settlement.

1978 A coup in PDRY brings radical Abdalfattah Ismail to power.

1980 Ismail replaced by moderate Ali Nasir Muhammad.

1986 Coup attempt in PDRY leads to civil war. Rebels take control of Aden.

1987 Oil production starts in YAR.

1990 Formal unification in May. Ali Saleh president of Republic of Yemen.

1991 Yemen opposes the US-led action against Iraq.

1997 President Saleh's GPC wins an absolute majority in general election.

2000 USS Cole is badly damaged by suicide attack in Aden harbor.

2004–05 Supporters of dissident cleric Hussein al-Houthi rebel in the north. Uprising ends with a pardon to the rebels.

2006 President Saleh is reelected.

2008 Clashes with Al-Houthi rebels and with protesters in Sana. Attack on the US embassy in Sana kills 18 people.

2009 A government offensive against the northern rebels; Saudi Arabian army involved in fighting the Yemeni rebels.

2010 A ceasefire is signed with northern rebels who release nearly 200 prisoners.

«158–59 Diffusion of Knowledge
«174–77 The Ascent of Islam

Oman



The oldest independent state in the Arab world, and until recently one of the most isolated.

700s CE Establishment of an independent Ibadi Imamate in Oman.

1507 Portuguese take control of Oman.

1650 Imam Nasir Ibn Murshid of the Yaariba dynasty expels the Portuguese.

1730 The Omanis conquer Portuguese settlements on the East Coast of Africa.

1743 The Persians capture Muscat.

1749 Ahmad Ibn Said is elected Imam as the Persians are expelled, and founds the Al-Said dynasty, which rules to the present day.

1913 Control of the country fractures. The interior is ruled by the Ibadite imams, while the sultan controls the coast.

1920 The sultan recognizes the autonomy of the interior in a peace agreement brokered by the British.

1932 Sultan Said bin Taimur comes to power. He adopts an isolationist, anti-Western approach.

1959 Bin Taimur regains control of the interior, responding to popular demands for complete independence.

1964 Oil reserves are discovered. Extraction begins three years later.

1965 Leftist forces in the southern region of Dhofar begin an uprising.

1970 Sultan Qaboos bin Said seizes power from his father in a bloodless coup. He begins a program of liberalization.

1975 Dhofar revolt is finally suppressed with the aid of troops from Jordan and Iran.

1991 Consultative Council set up as Sultan Qaboos allows limited elections.

1997 Women are allowed to stand and vote in elections to the Consultative Council. The first two women are elected.

1999 Oman and neighboring United Arab Emirates (UAE) sign an agreement ending a long-standing border dispute.

2003 Consultative Council members elected for first time, as all citizens over the age of 21 are allowed to vote. The vote had previously been limited to tribal leaders, chosen intellectuals, and businessmen.

2004 Oman appoints its first female minister.

«158–59 Diffusion of Knowledge
«174–77 The Ascent of Islam

DECISIVE MOMENT

IBN SAUD DEFEATS THE IKHWAN, 1930

In January 1930, a two-year civil war ended when the leaders of a military force known as the Ikhwan were captured by the British and handed over to Ibn Saud, the first king of Saudi Arabia.

Ibn Saud had established the Ikhwan in 1912 as an elite fighting unit educated in the Wahhabi tradition of Islam. But he had trained them too well. As he swept to victory against Ottoman rule, Ibn Saud began to cooperate with foreign powers, in particular the British. The Ikhwan saw this as a betrayal

and in 1928 they had rebelled. His defeat of the Ikhwan crushed all opposition and established the rule of the House of Saud.

Ikhwan on the move

Riding camels with banners flying, the Ikhwan were ferocious Bedouin soldiers driven by an Islamic fundamentalist zeal.

